(UTs) to draw funds from the State Disaster Response Fund (SDRF), in addition to the funds granted by the National Health Mission to expand medical infrastructure and testing capabilities.

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15 MARCH 2020

INDIA | 99 ACTIVE CASES | 2 DEATHS

WORLD | 1,31,723 ACTIVE CASES | 6,581 DEATHS

On 13 March, the prime minister, via his Twitter handle, announced that the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC) nations should get together in their fight against COVID-19: 'I would like to propose that the leadership of SAARC nations chalk out a strong strategy to fight Coronavirus. Together, we can set an example to the world, and contribute to a healthier planet.'[4]

The last SAARC Summit was held in November 2014 in Kathmandu, immediately after the prime minister was sworn in. The next scheduled one was to take place in November 2016, but due to heightened tensions between India and Pakistan over an attack on our military camp in Uri, the Summit was called off.[5] However, the prime minister always maintained his firm belief in his vision to emphasize the centrality of India's neighbourhood in its larger foreign policy agenda—Neighbourhood First Policy. With the COVID-19 pandemic looming and nations such as Sri Lanka, Bangaladesh and Nepal strongly advocating for SAARC to take action before the case numbers reached alarming levels, it was time for India, as a regional powerhouse, to extend and even lead strategic efforts which would benefit all the neighbourhood nations in the combined fight. In fact, hours after the prime minister's tweet, several SAARC leaders hailed the prime minister's move.[6]

PM Modi's tweet read, 'I would like to propose that the leadership of SAARC nations chalk out a strong strategy to fight Coronavirus. We could discuss, via video conferencing, ways to keep our citizens healthy. Together, we can set an example to the world, and contribute to a healthier planet.' The Prime Minister of Bhutan Lotay Tshering tweeted in a reply to his Indian counterpart Modi's tweet, 'This is what we call leadership. As members of this region, we must come together in such times. Smaller